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The Many Lives of Didi

- In January, Sandeshkhali explodes onto national headlines. TMC strongmen accused of a reign of sexual terror, corruption. Calls for President's rule in Bengal
- Unrest peters out after sting video suggests staged violence
- Mamata's TMC wins a long battle of attrition in the LS poll, winning 29 of 42 seats
- The rape and murder of a junior doctor spawns one of the biggest mass protests on the streets of Kolkata
- TMC sweeps all six seats in November bypolls

Mamata Banerjee wrote a memoir, titled *My Unforgettable Memories*, back in 2012. Still in her first year at Writers' Building, after a landmark agitation in Singur dislodged the long-incumbent and by then recumbent Left, it was meant as a mid-journey logbook. Jottings at the end of one phase of her 'rags-to-riches' life, it only marked the onset of another. Since then, she has been writing the subsequent chapters on the slate of Bengal's public life. Through exhausting electoral cycles, she has seen it all—cultic euphoria, high and low tides, survival anxiety. Yet, if an updated edition ever comes out, 2024 will contribute some unforgettable memories—many of the sort she'd like to forget. One of them even threatened to become her own Singur moment. As 2025 dawns, though, West Bengal will find her still very much in control, as she mostly has been through nearly 14 years as chief minister. There are also moments she will cherish, not least the way her Troy held on against a mighty electoral siege that lasted all through a heated summer.

Gender violence is the theme often used to tar Mamata's Bengal. Yet TMC boasts the largest contingent of women MPs in India

With her old bêtes noires tamed, what keeps her hands full is a foe with unanticipated potency in Bengal: the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Always on the prowl for a crack in her fortress, the saffronites managed to kick up a national shindig right in January, with an assortment of allegations against local Trinamool Congress strongmen in Sandeshkhali village—embezzlement of public funds, sexual terror, all-round goonery. That petered out eventually, in a trail of conflicting testimonies and sting videos suggesting staged drama. But the real hour of foreboding struck in August, after the tragic rape-murder of a trainee doctor at Kolkata's RG Kar Medical College. The air was thick with talk of an official cover-up and collusion in a gigantic web of medical corruption. Disgusted Kolkatans hit the streets like in an Occupy movement. For one who fed off mass adulation, it was the sternest test of her political life. But she rode it out tenaciously, engaging directly with the striking junior doctors, taxiing to a resolution. "I too want justice for the victim," she disarmingly.

Mamata is India's only woman chief minister, if you discount Delhi's caretaker CM Atishi. It's ironic that the one theme that stalks her is gender violence. That too when, just one turn of season before RG Kar, she had single-handedly fought off a determined grab at her territory by the BJP—remember, Bengal had its Lok Sabha voting agonisingly sliced up into all seven phases. In the end, it was she who pulled off a sweep, with masterfully nimble tactics yielding 29 of 42 seats, pegging the BJP down to 12. What's more, 11 of those were women, at 38 per cent the highest share for any Indian party. In November, a six-seat sweep in byelections (among them a woman) quieted all the RG Kar-inspired speculation on Mamata's longevity. If anything, within the INDIA bloc, given the Congress blip after Haryana and Maharashtra, her national ambitions—always subject to weather conditions—are no longer notional. ■